

Jumping and climbing

The animal world contains some big kickers, as well as expert climbers. Many small animals jump to make a fast escape, but kangaroos can keep hopping for nearly a mile before they start to tire. Although climbing is a slower way of moving, it lets animals get food that is hard to reach. Some climbers come down to breed, but many spend their whole lives high above the ground.

Knee joint is straight at end of kick



Liftoff!

With a powerful kick from its back legs, a red-eyed tree frog launches itself into the air. After liftoff, it spreads out its legs and toes, turning its body into a parachute as it sails through the air. Tree frogs have sticky toe-pads for getting a grip on leaves, and their forward-pointing eyes help them to judge distances before making a jump.

Suckerlike toe pads grip leaf's surface

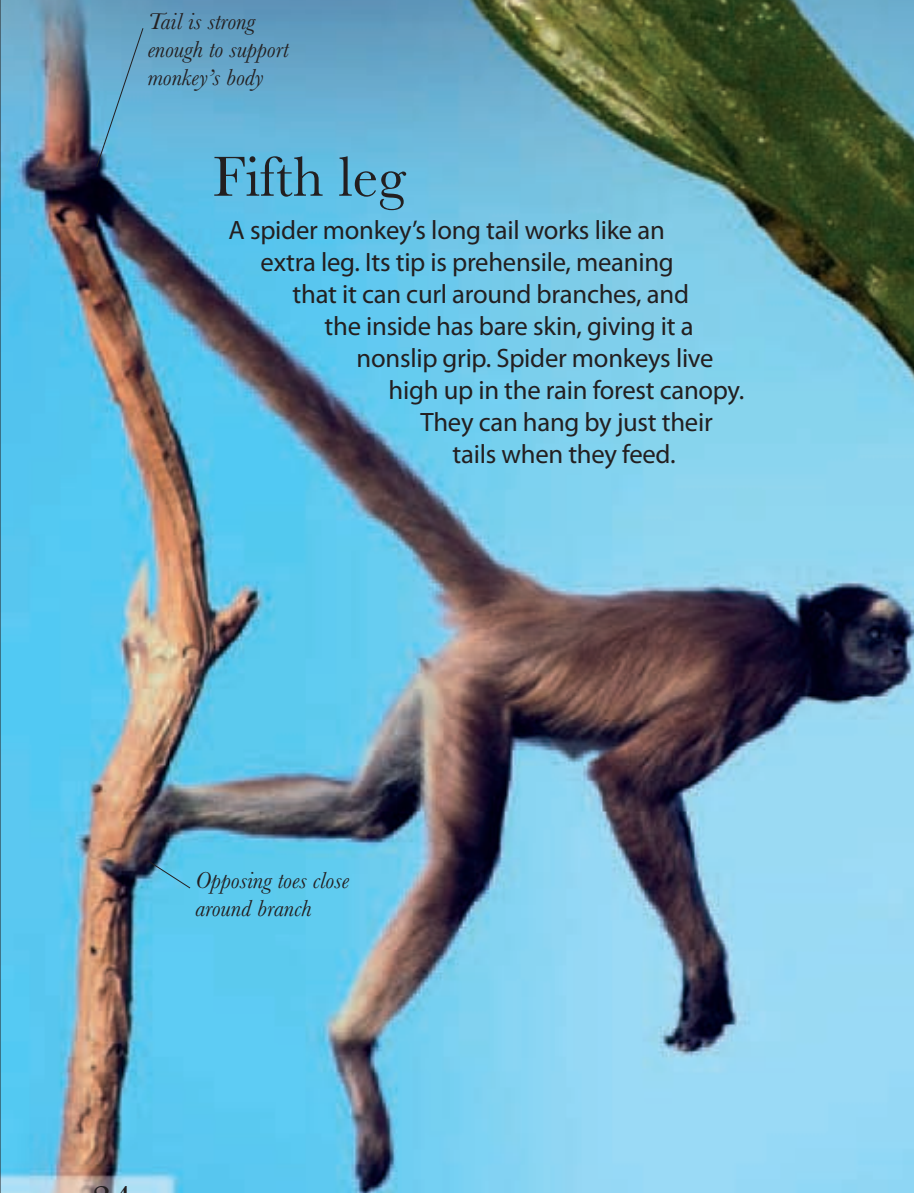


Tail is strong enough to support monkey's body

Fifth leg

A spider monkey's long tail works like an extra leg. Its tip is prehensile, meaning that it can curl around branches, and the inside has bare skin, giving it a nonslip grip. Spider monkeys live high up in the rain forest canopy. They can hang by just their tails when they feed.

Opposing toes close around branch



Holding tight

Climbing animals have many different ways of moving around without losing their grip.

Hooks

Lice are small insects that spend their lives aboard mammals and birds. Their legs end in sharp hooks that close around fur or feathers. To move, a louse releases its hooks in a set sequence, so that while some are moving, the rest are still holding tight.



Claws

Woodpeckers specialize in climbing tree trunks. Their claws dig in when they land on a tree, and their tails help to brace them when they feed. Woodpeckers can only climb upward, but nuthatches can climb both up and down without losing their grip.



Sticky toes

Geckos can climb almost any surface, including polished glass. They do this by using billions of microscopic bristles on the undersides of their toes. These stick to anything they touch. To move, a gecko carefully unpeels its toes, so that its bristles lose their grip.

